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GALLOWS WAY

A Tarot Horror Mystery

You have already seen what comes next. You simply do not know what it means.

A one-session game for one GM and 3-6 players.

Core Rules

This is the single source of truth for how Gallows Way plays. `build_booklet.py` renders this file (plus a roster pulled live from `cast/`) into the printable rulebook. If a generated PDF and this file ever disagree, this file is correct, regenerate the PDF.

Where mechanics here reference the Cast, the ten profiles in `cast/* .md` are the authoritative source for any character-specific detail (Stats, Weakness, Gift, Tool). Nothing in this document should describe a Cast ability that isn't written in `cast/`.

What you need

One light-backed Tarot deck for each player, one contrasting dark-backed Tarot deck for the GM, a Cast sheet for each player, pencils, and six Grounding tokens per player. Glass beads in a bowl work well. No dice are used.

Tone

Gallows Way is exploratory horror for one GM and 3-6 players (five Cast members chosen from the ten in `cast/`, plus the GM). Violence may occur, but combat is never the assumed solution. The house is the principal threat: stairs, locks, furniture, memories, etiquette, architecture, and ordinary accidents become its weapons. Avoid conventional monsters attacking on cue, the house's own fabric is scarier and more consistent with its established nature.

Before play

Each player chooses one member of the Cast. Give every character six Grounding tokens.

Prepare each player deck:

1. Separate the 22 Major Arcana from the 56 Minor Arcana.
2. Shuffle the Major Arcana and draw two without looking at them.
3. Shuffle those two cards into the Minor Arcana.
4. Set the remaining Major Arcana aside.
5. Place the deck face down and turn its top card face up.

The face-up top card is that character's **Premonition**. Everyone may see it. Whenever it is used or discarded, reveal the next card immediately. Routine actions do not consume cards; a Premonition is discarded only by a test, an ability, a Major effect, or an explicit consequence. Waiting does not make an unwanted future disappear.

Players may discuss their visible cards and coordinate around them. That is clairvoyance, not cheating. The limitation is fictional: the person taking the risk uses their own future, and a test cannot be transferred to whoever holds the strongest Premonition.

Making a test

Use the visible Premonition, add the relevant Stat, and compare the total with the Difficulty.

Difficulty	When to use
8	Favorable, but failure matters
10	Risky or uncertain
12	Severe danger or opposition
14	Extraordinary circumstances

Results:

- Exceed the Difficulty by 3 or more: the character succeeds cleanly.
- Meet the Difficulty or exceed it by 1 or 2: the character succeeds, but the GM introduces a consequence.
- Miss the Difficulty: the action fails and the situation changes for the worse.

Consequences can cost time, separate the group, consume equipment, expose a secret, inflict harm, remove Grounding, attract attention, alter a route, or let the House insert a card. Never repeat the same test without a meaningful change.

Call for a test only when the outcome is uncertain, failure would change the situation, and the character is exposed to the consequence. Never test merely to inspect scenery, open an ordinary drawer, or remember something the character would know.

Essential clues are never withheld behind a failed test. A test may determine how safely, quickly, or completely a clue is obtained, or what notices the investigator in return, never whether the core clue exists at all.

Tests follow the character taking the action; the group cannot transfer a test after hearing the required Stat. Once the GM names a test's Stat, Difficulty, and apparent danger, the action is committed and cannot be withdrawn.

One action at a time. When several people could act, the GM asks each what their character is doing before resolving anyone's action. Each character commits to one immediate action.

Choosing a Stat

Choose the Stat according to the obstacle the character must overcome and how they confront it, not merely the broad action they are attempting. The same goal can require different Stats when approached differently. Opening a sealed door might use Vigor to force it, Reason to defeat its mechanism, or Notice to find its concealed release. When two Stats honestly apply, the player describes how the character approaches the problem and the GM names the matching Stat before setting the Difficulty.

Notice

Notice is perception and awareness. It detects something present now but does not explain what that evidence means.

Examples:

1. Spot a tripwire before stepping through a doorway.
2. Hear movement inside a wall before whatever is there emerges.
3. Realize that a portrait's hands have changed position.
4. Catch someone slipping a key into their pocket.
5. Follow a faint trail of blood across a patterned carpet.

Use Reason, not Notice, when the important question is what the discovered evidence means.

Reason

Reason is intelligence, learned knowledge, judgment, and willpower. It interprets evidence, applies expertise, solves problems, and resists attempts to override the character's conscious mind.

Examples:

1. Reconstruct the order of events from marks left in a disturbed room.
2. Stabilize a badly bleeding wound with limited supplies before the patient goes into shock.
3. Recognize the contradiction in a supernatural command and reject it as an intrusion.
4. Work out how to stop a clockwork lock without triggering it.
5. Identify the historical purpose of a symbol carved into a lintel.

Use Notice, not Reason, when the challenge is finding or sensing the evidence in the first place.

Rapport

Rapport is charisma and social influence. It covers persuasion, empathy, reassurance, deception, intimidation, bargaining, and reading another person's emotional intent.

Examples:

1. Calm a panicking companion enough for them to follow instructions.
2. Persuade a hostile apparition to answer one question.
3. Convince a suspicious stranger that you belong in the house.
4. Recognize what subject a grieving spirit is refusing to discuss.
5. Negotiate terms with an entity offering safe passage.

Rapport influences another will. Reason or Nerve resists it, depending on how the character holds their ground.

Nerve

Nerve is stamina, pain tolerance, courage, and sanity. It governs how long the character can endure physical or psychological strain without breaking down.

Examples:

1. Cross a nursery while something unseen whispers your name.
2. Keep moving after hours without sleep or safe rest.
3. Keep treating an injury while a corpse speaks beside you.
4. Remain functional through severe pain until immediate danger passes.
5. Resist a supernatural command through courage and raw refusal to break.

A mental command may use Reason if the character exposes its falsehood, or Nerve if they endure its pressure through sheer grit.

Vigor

Vigor is strength, dexterity, agility, coordination, and athletics. It governs active physical performance rather than the stamina to endure prolonged strain.

Examples:

1. Force open a swollen wooden door before the corridor closes.
2. Climb a crumbling exterior wall in heavy rain.
3. Leap across a gap where the staircase has vanished.
4. Carry an injured companion away from a collapsing ceiling.
5. Pick a simple lock with improvised tools before approaching footsteps arrive.

Vigor handles active physical performance. Nerve handles prolonged exertion, pain, fear, and exhaustion.

Each Cast member has +4, +3, +2, +1, and +0 assigned once each across the five Stats (see **cast** / for exact assignments). The Stat measures capability; the card represents the future already waiting for them.

Reading the Minor Arcana

Card	Test value	Additional effect
Ace	Critical success	Regain 1 Grounding
2-10	Printed value	None
Page	11	None
Knight	12	None
Queen	Automatic success	Lose 1 Grounding
King	19	None

An Ace succeeds spectacularly regardless of Stat or Difficulty and returns one Grounding bead to the character, up to their starting maximum.

A Queen succeeds regardless of Stat or Difficulty, but the vision costs something vital: move one Grounding bead into the pool after resolving the action.

A King is not automatic. Treat it as 19 and add the Stat normally; this distinction matters if the house imposes an exceptional Difficulty or penalty.

The Four Suits

The suits are known to the players. They do not change the number or add a bonus. They tell everyone what kind of future surrounds the action and help the GM shape benefits and consequences. A suit is permission, not a command; the GM may make its influence subtle, and players should gradually recognize the house's recurring symbolic vocabulary.

- **Cups, emotion and memory.** Relationships, grief, desire, empathy, family, spirits, dreams, and recollection.
- **Pentacles, the material house.** Objects, evidence, money, bargains, possessions, architecture, doors, and physical traces.
- **Swords, danger and truth.** Fear, conflict, pain, separation, difficult knowledge, accusation, and decisive harm.
- **Wands, action and change.** Instinct, movement, ambition, transformation, fire, supernatural power, and things set in motion.

Major Arcana: House Layers

A Major Arcana is never used as a test value. The instant one becomes the active card, through revealing, an ability, or a House card, stop play and announce it.

The GM describes an immediate change that affects the whole house and establishes the card's ongoing Layer. Then reset every character's Premonition before play resumes: the character who revealed the Major discards it and reveals their next card; every other character discards their current Premonition without using it and reveals a new one. If another Major appears during the reset, finish resetting everyone, then resolve that Major normally.

Merely seeing a deeper Major through an ability does not activate it. It activates only when it reaches the top or is drawn for use.

A Layer usually lasts until another Major replaces it or until its fiction is resolved. It creates both danger and opportunity, and should never inflict unavoidable harm without giving the players something meaningful to do.

Repeated cards. If a Major appears again, intensify or transform its earlier meaning. The house remembers. A second Hermit might extinguish even personal lights; a second Lovers might bind enemies rather than friends; a second World might close every route except one.

Major Arcana I

- **The Fool.** Continuity is abandoned. Thresholds lead somewhere unexpected and new paths appear.
- **The Magician.** Tools and objects activate or perform impossible functions. Solutions demand deliberate use.
- **The High Priestess.** Silence and secrecy descend. Hidden things are easier to notice; speaking a truth may erase it.
- **The Empress.** Growth and hospitality become possessive. Roots spread, food freshens, and the house tries to nurture what it claims.
- **The Emperor.** Architecture imposes order. Doors lock, rooms acquire labels, and rank or rules suddenly matter.
- **The Hierophant.** Old customs resume. Etiquette, ritual, and household roles can protect those who obey them.

Major Arcana II

- **The Lovers.** Bonds become literal. Paired people share sensations, choices, locations, or consequences.
- **The Chariot.** The house moves. Corridors travel, staircases change direction, and entire rooms shift position.
- **Strength.** Restrained things test their bonds. Force worsens the danger; patience or compassion creates leverage.
- **The Hermit.** Isolation and darkness spread. Personal lights reveal things the house ordinarily hides.
- **Wheel of Fortune.** Rooms and consequences repeat in altered form. Something lost may return, but never unchanged.

Major Arcana III

- **Justice.** The house balances a debt with ancient, exacting fairness.
- **The Hanged Man.** Gravity or perspective overturns. Progress requires surrendering the obvious route.
- **Death.** Something ends and transforms. Death is not automatically physical or final.
- **Temperance.** Boundaries blend: rooms, times, people, and states of life overlap.
- **The Devil.** The house makes a tempting offer. Acceptance creates a bond or obligation.
- **The Tower.** Violent restructuring exposes what was concealed as routes and certainties collapse.

Major Arcana IV

- **The Star.** Genuine clarity arrives. For a moment, the house cannot completely falsify what is learned.
- **The Moon.** Perception, geography, and identity become unreliable, but every falsehood contains a contradiction.
- **The Sun.** Merciless exposure reveals hidden things, including truths the characters hoped to keep private.
- **Judgement.** The living and dead are called to account through confession, accusation, or request.
- **The World.** The house briefly aligns into a comprehensible whole. A route toward the center or exit appears as side paths close.

Helping and acting together

One character leads a test. A second character may help only by describing a concrete action that could change the outcome. Before the lead card is resolved, the helper commits their visible Premonition too.

If the helper's card plus their relevant Stat meets Difficulty 8, give the lead character +2. Otherwise give +1 and expose the helper to the consequence. Both committed cards are discarded. A Queen or Ace resolves its Grounding effect normally; a Major interrupts everything.

Helping is deliberately costly. It lets another player enter the danger; it is not a convenient way to dispose of a poor card.

Group dangers. When an event threatens everyone, do not ask one character to solve it for the table. Each endangered character tests the appropriate Stat, but their circumstances may differ: one holds the door, another guides someone through the dark, another resists the voice calling from upstairs.

The House Deck

The GM keeps a complete dark-backed Tarot deck as the House Deck. Its cards may be inserted into player decks when the house gains influence. Because the backs differ, a player can see the contamination approaching without knowing its face.

How close. Insertion distance is tied to the target's current Grounding. At 5-6 Grounding, insert within the next six cards. At 3-4, within the next four. At 1-2, within the next two. At 0, place it directly beneath the active card. Do not count exact positions aloud.

When revealed. A dark Minor Arcana still resolves at its normal value and retains any Ace, Queen, or King rule. In addition, the GM introduces an intrusion based on its suit: Cups disturb memory or feeling; Pentacles alter an object or route; Swords bring threat or painful truth; Wands set an unnatural change in motion. After resolution, return a dark card to the GM's discard pile rather than the player's discard pile.

Dark Major Arcana. A dark Major creates a House Layer like any other Major, but it should feel targeted at the character whose deck carried it. It may expose their Weakness, imitate an established personal detail, or reshape a room around something they brought into the house.

Grounding

Grounding measures a character's ability to distinguish themselves from the house and the future pressing upon them. Each character begins with six beads. Keep them visible near the character sheet.

Losing Grounding. Move a bead into the central pool when a Queen is used, when a rule specifically requires it, or when the GM offers Grounding loss as a consequence appropriate to psychic strain, isolation, possession, or surrendering part of oneself.

Regaining Grounding. An Ace returns one of that character's beads from the pool, up to six. Certain discoveries, honest connections, safe rooms, or a meaningful personal turning point may also restore Grounding at the GM's discretion.

At zero: Unmoored. An Unmoored character remains playable, but the boundary between character and house has opened. Turn their visible Premonition face down; they must now draw tests blindly. Whenever they fail a test or use a Queen, the GM may insert a House card directly beneath the top card instead of removing another Grounding.

An Unmoored character can recover only by an Ace, or by accepting meaningful help in a place of safety. There is no Anchor mechanic in the current Cast; nothing else restores an Unmoored character automatically. If a future character-specific Gift or Weakness is written to interact with Unmoored, it must be added to that character's file in **cast**/ first.

Physical harm

Physical harm is described specifically rather than tracked with points or boxes. A character might suffer a sprained ankle, a bleeding hand, a concussion, or broken ribs. The injury affects only actions it would reasonably hinder or prevent.

Failing a Vigor test does not automatically cause physical harm. The consequence follows the danger established before the test. Failing to lift a fallen beam may simply leave it blocking the way; failing to jump across a hole may cause a fall and an injury.

Call for another test only when an injury makes a later action dangerous or uncertain. Appropriate medical attention changes what the injury prevents or how it may worsen. Providing ordinary care does not require a test unless pressure, inadequate supplies, an unusual injury, or another meaningful uncertainty makes failure consequential.

Tools

A Tool can be used in any way the physical object reasonably permits. Its description establishes what the character carries and any unusual qualities it possesses; it does not limit the Tool to one listed action. Using a Tool does not require a test when it makes the outcome safe and certain. Call for a test only when meaningful danger or uncertainty remains.

The Cast

The one-shot uses ten premade archetypes, without fixed names, genders, or appearances, of which five are chosen for play. Each has a Bio, five Stats, a Weakness rooted in internal conflict, a Gift that manipulates their deck, an investigative Tool, and a blank Secret the player creates and conceals from the rest of the group.

The full roster, selection rules, and the Organizer procedure live in `cast/cast-index.md`. **`cast/* .md` is the single source of truth for every character-specific rule.** This document and any generated PDF only render what is written there; if a PDF ever shows a Gift, Weakness, or Tool that doesn't match the relevant `cast/* .md` file, the Markdown file is correct.

Status

All mechanics above are settled and used as-is by the PDF build. Open design questions (the final experiment, why the Cast was gathered, the exact escape conditions) are narrative canon decisions, not mechanical ones, and are tracked in `decision-log.md` and `canon/known-background.md`, not here.

GM Guide

Procedural and tone guidance for running Gallows Way. `rules/core-rules.md` covers the mechanics; this file covers how to run a session with them. Nothing here overrides a mechanic in `core-rules.md` or a character detail in `cast/`.

Enter Gallows Way

The visitors have come to spend one night inside an impossible New England mansion. Some were invited. Some were drawn here. Some have been looking for the house for years. Every one of them possesses a latent sense of what is about to happen.

The house has a hundred-plus rooms, although no plan agrees on where they belong. Its corridors lengthen, its doors reconsider their destinations, and its dead do not all want the same thing.

The visitors are not here to defeat the house. They are here to uncover what they can, survive until escape becomes possible, and decide what they are willing to leave behind.

A session will not traverse the whole manor. Expect a table to meaningfully visit somewhere between a dozen and twenty rooms in one sitting; the rest of the manuscript exists so the house can rearrange itself differently every time the group plays, and so no two tables walk the same route.

Building a mystery

For a one-shot, prepare three connected questions: one about the house, one about a past resident or event, and one about why these particular visitors were drawn here. Each answer should change what escape means.

Before running a session, the GM must also establish why the visitors came, what initially prevents escape, and two or three mysteries that can be meaningfully advanced in one session, consistent with `canon/known-background.md` and `canon/timeline.md`. Do not improvise an answer that contradicts locked canon; check `decision-log.md` first.

Clue structure

Place at least three independent clues toward every conclusion, in different forms: a physical trace, a document, a room's behavior, a spirit's testimony, an architectural contradiction, or a character's vision. Players receive the basic clue when they search the right place; tests control danger and interpretation, never whether the clue exists. See `clues/clue-index.md` for the current revelation-to-clue map.

- A clue may be incomplete, but it should point somewhere actionable.
- False testimony must have a reason: ignorance, loyalty, fractured memory, deliberate deception, or a different possible history.
- Avoid placing the whole explanation in one journal.
- Reuse room details already present in the manuscript whenever possible.
- Every major revelation should connect to at least one Cast member's background.

Room procedure

1. Give the room's immediate sensory impression.
2. Name several concrete features without ranking them.
3. Answer questions honestly from what is perceptible.
4. Introduce pressure only after the players engage.
5. Let their actions determine which possibilities become real.
6. Leave evidence of consequences when they return.

Escape

The front doors should not open merely because time passed. Escape becomes possible after the visitors learn a meaningful truth, satisfy or break a pattern, surrender something the house values, or exploit the brief alignment created by The World. They may escape without solving everything.

Running Gallows Way

Describe before you explain. Rooms should be detailed, tactile, and mostly plausible. Include several ordinary objects, one or two details that are slightly wrong, and multiple things that might become important. Do not announce the room's puzzle or prescribe its course. Let the players decide what deserves attention.

The house is the adversary. Use the setting as the weapon. A sticking lock, weak banister, overturned lamp, dumbwaiter, flooded stair, mislabeled medicine, or suddenly distant doorway is more appropriate than a monster arriving to attack.

Spirits disagree. The dead are not a united front. Some want release, recognition, revenge, company, silence, or protection from something else in the house. A frightening manifestation may be warning the characters; a comforting one may be recruiting them.

Ask characters, not the table. Address the person examining the desk, carrying the key, standing nearest the window, or already speaking to the apparition. Do not ask who wants to make the test after revealing which Stat is needed.

Keeping momentum. Address characters directly. Cut away after a consequential action. In urgent scenes, collect one declaration from everyone, then resolve them in the order demanded by the fiction. After two or three player actions, let the house act or change the pressure.

GM reference

Call for a test when the outcome is uncertain, failure changes the situation, and the character is exposed to the consequence. State Stat, Difficulty, and apparent danger first.

Consequences. Time passes | A route changes | The group separates | An object breaks or vanishes | Someone is physically harmed | A secret becomes public | A spirit notices | Grounding is lost | A dark card is inserted | Success creates an obligation.

Difficulty. 8 favorable | 10 risky | 12 severe | 14 extraordinary.

Minor Arcana. Ace: critical + regain Grounding | Page 11 | Knight 12 | Queen: automatic + lose Grounding | King 19.

House cards by Grounding. 5-6: next six | 3-4: next four | 1-2: next two | 0: directly beneath.

Spotlight rhythm. Collect one action from everyone in urgent scenes. Resolve one action at a time. The test follows the acting character. After two or three player actions, let the house respond.

Major Arcana. Interrupt | announce | alter the whole house | establish a Layer | reset every Premonition | resolve any new Major | resume action.

The Cast

Ten premade archetypes; five are chosen for play. Each has a Bio, five Stats, a Weakness, a Gift, a Tool, and a player-created Secret. This roster is a quick reference only, full dossiers are in *Mourning Bluff Manor Character Profiles*, and individual print-and-play packets exist for the characters currently offered as a selected set.

The Historical Archaeologist

Nerve +2 | Notice +4 | Rapport +1 | Reason +3 | Vigor +0

Someone anonymously sent you a box containing photographs, floor plans, correspondence, and property records from Mourning Bluff Manor that have never appeared in any archive. The documents establish that a previously unknown inheritor now owns the estate. The inheritor asked you to investigate the property and prove that its infamous hauntings are tricks, misunderstandings, or stories grown wild with age.

The Relative

Nerve +4 | Notice +2 | Rapport +3 | Reason +0 | Vigor +1

Someone you love became obsessed with Mourning Bluff Manor and disappeared while trying to reach it. The authorities found no evidence that they ever entered the estate. When you learned that the new inheritor was allowing a private investigation, you demanded a place in the group. You are not interested in ghost stories. You want to discover what happened and, against all reason, still hope to bring them home.

The Fraudulent Medium

Nerve +2 | Notice +3 | Rapport +4 | Reason +1 | Vigor +0

You make a living pretending to speak with the dead. Outwardly, you perform with absolute confidence; privately, you believe you are a fraud who has mistaken instinct and coincidence for something more. But once, and only once, you had a vision you could not explain. You saw Mourning Bluff Manor, including details you later confirmed had never been made public. You have come to the house grasping for proof that the vision was real and that perhaps you have not been pretending all this time.

The Paramedic

Nerve +3 | Notice +1 | Rapport +0 | Reason +2 | Vigor +4

One of the people entering Mourning Bluff Manor is your friend, and you insisted on coming because someone needed to take the ordinary dangers seriously. You do not necessarily believe the house is haunted, but you do believe in rotten floorboards, rusty nails, asbestos, unstable stairs, and being hours away from medical help. Once people start getting hurt, it does not matter who brought you here. You are the person with the training to keep them alive.

The Psychic Researcher

Nerve +3 | Notice +2 | Rapport +1 | Reason +4 | Vigor +0

You study clairvoyance, precognition, and anomalous perception through controlled experiments. You want psychic phenomena to be real, but every case you have examined has collapsed under scrutiny, produced inconclusive results, or could not be repeated. When invited to join the investigation of Mourning Bluff Manor, you accepted the opportunity to observe a reputed haunting firsthand. You are not there to communicate with the dead or explain away what happens. You want to determine whether genuine psychic phenomena can be measured, repeated, and quantified.

The Psychiatrist

Nerve +1 | Notice +0 | Rapport +4 | Reason +3 | Vigor +2

You were the attending psychiatrist responsible for the last known person to enter Mourning Bluff Manor. They returned alive but profoundly disturbed, unable to separate memories from hallucinations or describe the house without contradicting themselves. Nothing you tried restored them, and their condition has continued to deteriorate. You have entered the manor to understand what happened to your patient and determine whether the source was trauma, delusion, or something you were never trained to diagnose.

The Detective

Nerve +1 | Notice +4 | Rapport +0 | Reason +3 | Vigor +2

You spent years investigating disappearances connected to Mourning Bluff Manor. What began as an overlooked pattern became the only case that mattered to you. Your superiors called your conclusions speculative, then reckless, and finally removed you from the investigation. You are officially on administrative leave and have been ordered to stay away. You have entered the manor anyway, determined to find the evidence that proves the disappearances are connected, and that you were right to keep digging.

The Priest

Nerve +0 | Notice +2 | Rapport +4 | Reason +3 | Vigor +1

You have spent years listening to people describe grief, guilt, visions, and experiences they believe were supernatural. Most needed compassion more than an exorcism. When the new inheritor sought help concerning Mourning Bluff Manor, you agreed to enter, investigate its stories, and determine whether the house requires a blessing, a more serious spiritual intervention, or no religious response at all. You are here to protect the living before passing judgment on the dead.

The Dreamer

Nerve +3 | Notice +4 | Rapport +2 | Reason +1 | Vigor +0

You have walked the rooms of Mourning Bluff Manor in your dreams for months, recognizing people you have never met and always waking before you reach the same locked door. Recently the dreams changed: five visitors entered the house together, and one of them was you. When you discovered that an investigation was actually being organized, you contacted the others because you already knew where and when they would meet.

The Inheritor

Nerve +3 | Notice +1 | Rapport +2 | Reason +0 | Vigor +4

You are an ordinary person who has unexpectedly become the legal owner of Mourning Bluff Manor. You have always been more comfortable with training, competition, and physical problems than old documents or ghost stories, and you want nothing to do with the house. Your mother was obsessed with it, but she died when you were very young. After her death, your father destroyed everything she had collected about the manor and refused to speak of it again. Now the estate has passed to you, bringing her obsession back into your life. You have come to understand why she cared about this place and decide what must be done with it.

THE HOUSE HAS SEEN YOU COMING.

Premonitions reveal the value of the next card, but never the moment that will demand it. Spend certainty carefully. Gallows Way is always arranging another room.